

Personal-Finance Software

If you're willing to invest the time, a personal-finance software program can bring your money management to a whole new level, but you don't need to do more than the basics if you don't have the time or interest. Unless you have very few expenses and they're relatively simple, a good software program will make the job of tracking everything easier and less time-

consuming. If you don't want to use a computer, that's okay too. It's entirely possible to budget successfully with paper and pencil.



Many banks now offer free or low-fee online banking and free personal-finance software. You simply log in to your account and view your transactions and checks. You can even download this information into your personal-finance software, then indicate an expense category for each transaction and click a button for a report.

How Can Software Make Budgeting Easier?

With personal-finance software, you can balance your checkbook, pay bills, create budgets, and do a basic comparison of budget versus actual expenses by category. You can also enter more detailed information such as investments, assets, liabilities, and so on, and print personal financial statements showing your net income and net worth.

Start out with the simplest steps. Detailed tracking of investments with personal-finance software can be time-consuming and complex—not for the faint of heart. You can get the same results in your reports by setting up an account in the software for each investment and changing the balances each